As with Pakistan, then, India's pursuit of improved Indo-Pakistani relations has not resulted from nuclear deterrence. Rather, it is the product primarily of shifting domestic priorities and nonnuclear strategic calculations. And the Indian government's political will to continue its rapprochement with Pakistan could dissolve in the event of another Parliament-like terrorist assault. In fact, Indian strategists are actively preparing for the possibility of such an occurrence. These preparations may significantly affect the balance of power in the South Asian region and could exacerbate regional security-dilemma dynamics, increasing the likelihood of conflict. Thus nuclear weapons have had little to do with the current Indo-Pakistani rapprochement. In fact, by facilitating past disputes, nuclear weapons have unleashed strategic developments that may destabilize South Asia well into the future.

NUCLEAR WEAPONS AND FUTURE INSTABILITY Nuclear weapons facilitated provocative behavior as Pakistan acquired a de facto nuclear capability in the 1980s, encouraging Pakistan to provide the Kashmir insurgency with extensive political and material support. And nuclear weapons promoted further Pakistani adventurism in the wake of the 1998 tests, thereby triggering major Indo-Pakistani crises such as the Kargil war and the 2001–2002 standoff. Significantly, the effect of these crises has not been limited to the past. They have had a profound effect on current Indian strategic thinking, inspiring an aggressive shift in India's conventional military posture. This shift could increase the likelihood of serious Indo-Pakistani conflict in years to come.

The emerging strategic dangers are twofold. First, India is in the process of significantly expanding its conventional military capabilities. From 2001 to 2006, the Indian defense budget increased by 60 percent, from $13.81 billion to $22.1 billion. Between 2007 and 2012 India is forecast to spend up to $40 billion solely on weapons procurement, including fighter aircraft, artillery, submarines, armor, and an aircraft carrier.[59] Indian officials hope that this push to modernize Indian military forces will see an increase in defense spending from roughly 2 to about 3 percent of the GDP.[60]

These plans for Indian military expansion are not directed solely at Pakistan, or at any other country. To a significant degree, they result